

OWLS—THE NIGHT HUNTERS

Owls are one of the most characteristic birds of woodland areas. They have short, rounded wings so they can fly easily between the trees. They have large eyes and can turn their heads right around to see behind them. Most owls are night hunters, using their sharp hearing and eyesight to catch food in the dark.

Many owls have round faces, which act like radar dishes, funneling the sounds to their ear openings. The openings lie under feathered flaps of skin on the sides of their faces.



Flight feathers have a soft fringe to break up the flow of air and muffle the sound of the wings. Owls make very little noise as they fly.

Owls have powerful legs with needle-sharp, curved talons for gripping prey.



The owl's outer toe can point either forward or backward for extra grip.



A woodland owl swoops silently down from a perch, swinging its feet forward to grab its prey. It swallows prey, such as mice and voles, whole, head first. It cannot digest bones, fur, or feathers, so it coughs these up as pellets.

Northern cardinal

Northern cardinals have a rich variety of songs and males and females may sing in turn as if replying to each other. Unlike other birds that live in territories just for the breeding season, cardinals sing all year to keep other birds away. The cardinal is named after the bright red robes worn by Roman Catholic cardinals.

The male cardinal is more colorful than the female.

Male

Female



Northern cardinal
(*Cardinalis cardinalis*)
Length: 9 in (23.5 cm)

Ruffed grouse

In spring, the male ruffed grouse often sits on a log and makes a drumming sound by beating his wings to and fro. The sound gets faster and faster, carrying a long way through the forest and helping attract a female. She nests among aspen trees, feeding on the tree catkins while she sits on her eggs to keep them warm. In winter, ruffed grouse grow comblike bristles on their toes that act as snowshoes.

Ruffed grouse
(*Bonasa umbellus*)
Length: 1 ft 7 in (48 cm)

Mottled feathers ensure the bird is well camouflaged among dead leaves.



Eastern whip-poor-will
(*Antrostomus vociferus*)
Length: 11 in (27 cm)

Eastern whip-poor-will

During the day, the eastern whip-poor-will sleeps on the forest floor. Its mottled colors match the dead leaves so it is hard to see. At night, it flies near the ground with its mouth open, scooping up flying insects. The bird is so named because of its call which sounds like "whip-poor-will." It may repeat the call a hundred times or more without stopping.

American robin

This robin originally nested in open woodlands but has adapted well to suburban gardens. It often builds a nest on a house porch or in a nearby tree. It eats insects and worms, but also likes fruit, especially in winter. It sometimes spends the winter in northern conifer forests, gathering in large roosts of thousands of birds.

American robins have keen eyesight for finding worms.

American robin
(*Turdus migratorius*)
Length: 11 in (28 cm)

